

But there is more to the story. The way inspiration works varies with the type of literature.

1) Strictly speaking, ‘revelation’ signifies information given directly to someone by the Creator (sometimes using an angel). True prophecy is a prophet repeating verbatim what the Creator said to him: “the word of the LORD came to me saying” (Jeremiah 1:4). Of necessity, the information contained in the first chapter of Genesis was given directly to Adam by the Creator. Similarly, the information contained in Job 1:6-12 and 2:1-7 had to be given directly to the author of the book (perhaps Elihu, the son of Barachel—Job 32:2). Acts 1:16 says that the Holy Spirit spoke by the mouth of David. With reference to the ‘Lord’s Supper’, Paul wrote: “I received from the Lord that which I also transmitted to you” (1 Corinthians 11:23). I could add further references, but I have given enough to illustrate ‘revelation’; such revelation is usually normative, it serves to orient our behavior.

2) Historical information is somewhat different; inspiration guarantees the veracity of what is described—things happened in just that way. It should be obvious that descriptions of sin, lying, crime, or perversity are not normative, although they serve as negative examples to warn us. Genesis 3:4 registers a lie; “Then the serpent said to the woman: You will not surely die”. Obviously inspiration is not agreeing with the lie, it merely guarantees that the serpent said precisely that. Historical information, or record, may include normative orientation. It is always necessary to pay close attention to the context, that may appropriately be called the ‘king of interpretation’.

3) Poetic material is more difficult. It is a genre of communication that has its own rules, and the context is most important. The Song of Solomon is made up of thirteen ‘canticles’; they are not presented as being normative. Since the relationship between man and woman is fundamental to human existence, it is natural that the subject finds a place in the written Revelation. That the Creator chose the poetic genre, was His prerogative, and it goes with the subject matter; emotion often finds expression in poetic form.

In contrast, the Proverbs are generally normative. In Ecclesiastes 12:9-11, Solomon declares the inspiration of the proverbs: they were “given by one Shepherd”.

On the other hand, Solomon himself does not make the same claim for Ecclesiastes, another book that he wrote. The second verse, “Vanity of vanities, says the preacher, Vanity of vanities, all is vanity”, obviously